Following the meeting, the prime minister put out on his Twitter account along with an infographic with a few points to follow for basic protective measures: ‘Had an extensive review regarding preparedness on the COVID-19 novel coronavirus. Different ministries & states are working together, from screening people arriving in India to providing prompt medical attention. There is no need to panic. We need to work together, take small yet important measures to ensure self-protection.’[4]

The festival of Holi, which is celebrated all over India by meeting friends and family, was coming up in a couple of days. If it was going to be celebrated as usual, there would be a lot of people-to-people contact, thus providing a fertile ground for the virus to spread. The prime minister knew that he needed to send out a cautionary message. This was the beginning of increasingly ominous warnings about the impending cataclysmic crunch point that the prime minister would have to give. It was his unique way of impressing upon the country on what not to do—the first of many such call-to-action sermons—that would follow over the course of the pandemic. He tweeted on 4 March 2020: ‘Experts across the world have advised to reduce mass gatherings to avoid the spread of COVID-19 novel coronavirus. Hence, this year I have decided not to participate in any Holi Milan programme.’[5] Several other political leaders across party lines followed suit.[6]

India was, in no uncertain terms, unprepared for an epidemic and the briefings that the prime minister held would make that crystal clear to him. On the Global Health Security Index published in 2019, India ranked 57th in the world to produce a ‘rapid response to and mitigation of the spread of an epidemic’.[7] There was no doubt in the prime minister’s mind that in order to stand steadfastly against the virus, the whole country would have to follow the doctors’ orders: social distancing, self-quarantining, ramping up testing and scaling up capacities. And he would have to respond as the leader of a nation at war with this hidden enemy.

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On 4 March, at noon, Principal Secretary Dr Mishra chaired a review meeting in the PMO which was a prelude to an important briefing meet in which the prime minister would be informed on crucial matters.[8] The list of high-ranking bureaucrats and experts who attended the meeting gave off the